

The Home Theater Planning & Budget Guide

What a custom home theater really costs in San Antonio, and how to plan one you'll love

From KZ Audio & Video, home theater and AV specialists serving San Antonio and the Texas Hill Country since 1999.

Why this guide exists

The first question everyone has about a home theater is the one nobody wants to answer straight: what does it cost? Most companies dodge it. We won't.

This guide gives you honest budget ranges, explains what actually drives the price, and walks you through how a great theater comes together so you can plan with confidence instead of guessing.

The honest budget ranges

Every project is different, but here is roughly where real San Antonio installations land:

What you want	Typical starting budget
A surround sound system (speakers and receiver, added to a TV you already have)	\$3,000 to \$5,000 (Dolby Atmos \$6,000 to \$7,000)
A projector and screen (video only, no speakers)	\$3,500 to \$8,000, laser \$8,000 to \$18,000
A full media room (TV or projector, sound, lighting)	From \$10,000
A dedicated, custom-built home theater	\$15,000 and up
Whole-house audio	About \$1,900 per zone
Outdoor entertainment (patio TV, weatherproof audio)	From \$2,500

These are starting points. A theater is like a kitchen remodel: the range is wide because the choices are yours. The number that matters is the one we give you after we see your room, and we give that for free.

What actually drives the cost

- 1 The room.** A dedicated room you can control (light, sound, layout) costs more to build but delivers the best result. A media room that shares space with the rest of the house is more flexible and usually less.
- 2 Screen choice.** A large TV is simpler and often cheaper. A projector and screen give you the true cinema feel and scale up in price with brightness and resolution.

- 3 **The sound system.** This is where the experience lives. 5.1 surround is the entry point. 7.1, Dolby Atmos, and dual subwoofers add immersion and cost.
- 4 **Seating and finish.** Power recliners, tiered platforms, acoustic panels, and lighting turn a room into a theater. They are optional, and they add up.
- 5 **Automation.** One remote or one tap on your phone to dim the lights, drop the screen, and start the movie. Convenience that costs more but changes how often you actually use the room.

The choices worth understanding before you spend

Projector or TV?

A TV is brighter, simpler, and great for rooms with windows. A projector gives you a 100-inch-plus picture and the real theater feel, but it wants a room you can darken. Neither is "better." It depends on your room and how you'll use it.

How big should the screen be?

Bigger is not always better. The right size depends on how far back you sit. Too big and you're turning your head during the movie. We size the screen to your seating distance so every seat is the best seat.

How many speakers?

5.1 (five speakers and a subwoofer) is a real surround experience. 7.1 adds rear channels. Dolby Atmos adds overhead speakers for sound that moves around and above you. If you're building or wiring now, plan for more than you think you need. It's far cheaper to wire for it than to add it later.

How a great theater comes together

- 1 **Free in-home consultation.** We come to you, look at the actual room, and talk through what you want and what your budget is. No pressure, no sales pitch, just honest answers.
- 2 **Custom design.** We spec the system around your room and how your family watches, not a package we're trying to sell.
- 3 **Clean installation.** Our own team does the work. Wires hidden, everything level, everything labeled.
- 4 **Calibration.** This is the step most installers skip. We tune the picture and the sound to your specific room so it looks and sounds the way it's supposed to.
- 5 **The walkthrough.** We don't leave until you know how to use it and everything works.

How to tell a good installer from a cheap one

Ask these questions before you hire anyone:

- Do you use subcontractors, or does your own team do the work?
- Do you calibrate the picture and sound, or just plug it in?
- Will you hide all the wires, including in-wall?
- Can I see photos of your actual completed theaters?
- Do you stay until I understand how to use the system?

The cheapest quote is rarely the cheapest project. A system that's wired wrong or never calibrated costs you more in do-overs and frustration than doing it right the first time.

A note on who we are

KZ Audio & Video has been doing this since 1999. Every installation is done by our own team, Kelly, Billy, and Julian, and we have never used subcontractors. We design around your room, we calibrate everything, and we stay until it's right. We're rated 5.0 stars on Google by San Antonio homeowners.

Ready to plan your theater? Call or text Kelly at **(210) 981-4098**, or visit **kzaudioandvideo.com** to book your free in-home consultation.

KZ Audio & Video · In the AV business since 1999 · No subcontractors, ever